shifted most of its resources to Iraq and was requesting both NATO and non-NATO allies for support in Afghanistan.

Kutty's murder stood in contrast with what India had experienced in December 2003, when Mullah Sabir Momim of the Taliban kidnapped two Indian workers.[9] P. Murali, a lab technician, and G. Varda Rao, a plant operator, worked with a US company on the Kandahar-Kabul road project in Zabul. Accusing them of being Indian spies, Momin threatened assassination unless Kabul released fifty imprisoned militants.[10] Katju, then India's ambassador to Kabul, was able to secure their release with help from Afghan tribal elders who negotiated with the Taliban. The motive for the 2003 kidnappings was rooted in local politics and financial interests of the Taliban instead of targeting Indians per se. Neither of the two hostages was mistreated.[11] Kutty's case, however, became a fiery political issue because an Indian government employee was killed on duty. Adding fuel to fire, and in contrast to what Sinha told Blake, Narayanan candidly linked the incident to Pakistan (only to retract the statement later) as the opposition criticised the government for mishandling the situation.[12]

Questions about the efficacy of India's Afghanistan policy, the effectiveness of its intelligence and ITBP personnel deployed to protect Indian workers, the utility of not engaging with the Taliban, and countering of Pakistan's obstructionist role in Afghanistan, were raised in the parliament.[13] If this was not enough, an Indian telecommunications engineer, K. Suryanarayana, who worked for a Bahraini company in Zabul, was abducted in April 2006 and killed within two days.[14] In clockwork fashion, as Indian and Afghan agencies went about locating the kidnapper's coordinates, Narayanan reached out to his Pakistani counterpart Tariq Aziz in a back-channel effort to secure Suryanarayana's release and was met with denial.[15] Suryanarayana was beheaded without any talks, leading to a national outcry. Opposition leaders such as Advani criticised the government for not valuing national interests, adopting a 'kid-glove approach to jihadi terrorism', and for not taking the threat to Indians in Afghanistan seriously.[16] A furious and frustrated India directly blamed Pakistan for sponsoring the attack this time around. Even Sinha, who had downplayed Pakistan's role in Kutty's killing, blamed Pakistan in confidential meetings with US diplomats.[17]